Koran and presented them to the Padshah. According to the *Maasir ul-Umara*, Akbar was thoroughly shaken by this sign of ostentatious piety in his famously rationalist friend and said, 'He incites us to other kinds of things, and then when he goes to the privacy of his home he acts differently.' The *Iqbal Nama-i-Jahangiri*[†] also recorded Akbar's displeasure when Shaikh Mubarak wrote a commentary on the Koran without alluding to the Padshah himself, which Abu'l Fazl then sent to various dignitaries. From then on, noted historian Shamsauddaula Shah Nawaz, there was a slackening of the earlier bond that drew the two men together. For Shaikh Mubarak and his sons, marked forever by the ulema's long-ago persecution, the true nature of their own personal faith would always remain hidden by their pragmatic adoption and brilliant exposition of the Padshah's views.

Whatever Abu'l Fazl's motivations, he worked unceasingly on the *Akbarnama*. The Padshah listened to each page of the text as it was read out to him, using his prodigious memory to verify facts and occurrences. It was said that Abu'l Fazl wrote five drafts of the manuscript. Besides scrutinizing the text, Akbar took an inordinate amount of interest in the illustrations that accompanied the writing. Between 1590 and 1595, concurrently with the shaping of the text, miniatures were painted of various episodes described and it is believed that Akbar was closely involved in deciding which particular moments in his life were to be painted. Indeed, in the eyes of some experts, the illustrations are thought to give us a more accurate reflection of the Padshah's own view of his life than Abu'l Fazl's text.

Forty-nine artists were listed as being part of the project and they included all the leading masters of the age. These were collaborative works involving several artists working together and effortlessly using the Persian vertical use of space, European perspective, and indigenous vibrancy and luminous colour. A large number of the painters were Hindus of the agricultural Ahir caste, men with names like Kesu, Madhu, Mukund, Nand, Narayan, Paras, Shankar, Surdas, Ramdas, and Basawan. This accounts for the effervescence and dramatic energy of the paintings, a style favoured by Akbar. The famous Muslim painters of this taswir khana included Miskin, Mansur, Qutb Chela, and the Persian Farrukh Beg. The great Persian master Abd al-Samad was not included in this project and had presumably already retired, after training his two sons, Muhammad Sharif and Bihzad. Abd al-Samad painted one last painting at this time, a work created purely from